

The college applications glossary

Every confusing term explained in plain English, no fluff.

If you have ever nodded along while someone said spike, holistic review, or superscore and had absolutely no idea what they meant, this one is for you. Every term in here is something real students told us they were confused about while applying. No jargon, no long lectures, just what these words actually mean and why they matter for your application.

Application types and deadlines

Early Decision (ED)

Binding. If a school accepts you through ED, you are committing to attend and you withdraw every other application. Only do this for a school you are completely sure about.

Early Decision II (ED2)

Same binding commitment as ED, just with a later deadline, usually around January. A solid option if your first choice ED did not work out.

Early Action (EA)

You apply early and hear back early, but there is no obligation to attend. You can still compare offers and decide later.

Restrictive Early Action (REA)

Non binding like regular EA, but the school requires that you do not apply early anywhere else at the same time.

Regular Decision (RD)

The standard deadline, usually in January, with no early commitment either way.

Rolling Admission

The school reviews applications as they arrive instead of waiting for one deadline. Applying earlier usually means more spots are still open.

Deferred

Not a rejection. Your application simply moves from the early round into the regular round for another look.

Waitlisted

You are still technically in the running, but only if spots open up after everyone else responds.

How schools actually decide?

Holistic review

Grades and test scores are only part of the picture. Admissions officers are also weighing your essays, activities, recommendations, and how it all fits together as one person.

Demonstrated interest

Some schools quietly track how much genuine interest you show, campus visits, opening emails, interviews, and factor that into their decision.

Legacy

Having a parent or sibling who attended the school. It can help at some private schools. It does nothing at most others.

First generation student

Neither parent completed a four year degree, a status many schools consider during review.

Yield

The percentage of admitted students who actually enroll. Schools care about this because it affects their rankings, so it quietly shapes how many people they admit each year.

Your transcript and testing

Weighted vs unweighted GPA

Unweighted GPA treats every class the same. Weighted GPA gives extra points for harder classes like AP or IB, so your weighted number can be higher than 4.0.

Class rank

Where you stand compared to the rest of your grade. Some schools still report it, many have stopped.

AP, IB, and A Levels

Different systems for taking harder, college level classes while still in school. Doing well in any of them can strengthen your application.

Dual enrollment

Taking an actual college course while still in high school, sometimes earning credit for both at once.

Test optional

You get to choose whether to submit SAT or ACT scores at all.

Test blind

The school will not look at test scores even if you send them.

Superscore

The school takes your best section scores across multiple test dates and combines them into one final score.

Building your profile beyond grades

Extracurricular tiers

Admissions counselors informally rank activities by impact. National level recognition sits higher than simply being a club member.

Spike

Your one clear, standout strength or interest that makes you memorable, instead of being decent at ten different things. This is often more powerful than being well rounded.

Passion project

Something you built or started on your own because you actually cared about it, not because a teacher assigned it.

Independent research project

A self directed investigation into a real question, usually guided by a mentor, that produces an actual paper or result.

Portfolio

A collection of creative or design work required for art, architecture, or music applications.

The actual paperwork

Common App

One application you fill out once and send to hundreds of schools across the US.

Coalition App

A smaller alternative to the Common App, accepted by a different set of schools.

UCAS

The UK equivalent, used for applying to universities there.

Supplemental essays

Extra, school specific essays on top of your main essay. This is where a lot of actual decisions get made, so never treat them as an afterthought.

Letters of recommendation

Written by teachers or counselors who can speak to who you are as a person, not just your grades.

Activities list

A short summary of everything you do outside class, ranked by how much it actually matters to you.

Money terms, the short version

FAFSA

The US federal aid form, mostly for US citizens and residents. Most international students will not use this one.

CSS Profile

The form many private US schools use to calculate financial aid for both US and international students.

Merit aid

Money given for your achievements, completely separate from your family's income.

Need based aid

Money given based on what your family can genuinely afford. This is exactly what our other guide on need blind versus need aware breaks down in detail.

After you hit submit

Gap year

Taking a year off between high school and university. It is far more common and far more accepted than most people assume.

Binding vs non binding

Whether you are contractually required to attend if accepted. ED is binding. EA and RD are not.

Appeal

Asking a school to reconsider a decision. Rarely successful, and only worth attempting if you genuinely have new information to add.

One last thing

This is not every term you will ever come across. Admissions vocabulary keeps expanding every year. But this covers the words that came up most in our student survey. If you are still stuck on something, that confusion is exactly why the rest of this site exists.

Policies may change. Always verify details on each university's official admissions website.

sorted.